

md2D / md3D Practical Guide

Recipes for everyday studies: scans, convergence checks, lamellar and multilayer structures, rough surfaces, near-field maps and 3D structures, plus a troubleshooting table. The user manual defines every parameter used here.

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|--|--|
| 1. Organising a study | 6. Near-field maps |
| 2. Scanning a parameter | 7. 3D structures and conical incidence |
| 3. Checking convergence | 8. Material indices |
| 4. Lamellar gratings and stacks | 9. Troubleshooting |
| 5. Rough surfaces and non-periodic objects | 10. Older material in the repository |

1 Organising a study

- Use one folder per study, holding the parameter file, the structure file and a script. Run the programs from that folder, since results are written to the current directory.
- Keep the parameter file for what does not change and give what varies on the command line. Build `profile_name` from the varying values: it names the result file, it may contain a sub-folder (`-profile_name scan/theta_30`), and a run overwrites an existing file of the same name.
- Start from a validated case in `thesis_validation_cases/` that resembles your structure. Its `param.txt` is known to work.

2 Scanning a parameter

One run per value, then one pass to collect the results. The example scans the angle of incidence for the aluminium grating of the manual's first run.

```
#!/bin/sh
# scan.sh - angle scan, results in scan/theta_<angle>.txt
MD2D=${MD2D:-$HOME/DifferentialMethod/md2D/md2D}
mkdir -p scan
for t in 0 10 20 30 40; do
    "$MD2D" -param tayeb_alu.txt -theta_i $t -verbosity 0 -profile_name scan/theta_$t
done
```

```
# collect.py - one line per angle
import sys; sys.path.insert(0, "/path/to/DifferentialMethod/thesis_validation_cases/tools")
from mdres import eff          # eff(file, "r|"t", n) for md2D, eff(file, "r|"t", nx, ny) for md3D
for t in (0, 10, 20, 30, 40):
    f = "scan/theta_%d.txt" % t
    print(t, eff(f, "r", 0), eff(f, "r", -1))
```

An order that is evanescent at some angle returns `None`. Wavelength scans work the same way with `-lambda`. If the indices change with wavelength, pass them too: `-n_sub_re ... -n_sub_im ...` (md2D) or `-nu_sub_re ... -nu_sub_im ...` (md3D). Independent runs can go in parallel (`&` and `wait`, or GNU `parallel`), one per core.

3 Checking convergence

Do this once per new kind of structure, on the most demanding configuration: the largest angle, the shortest wavelength and TM polarisation.

```
for NS in 250 500 1000 2000; do md2D -param p.txt -NS $NS -verbosity 0 -profile_name conv/NS$NS; done
for N in 20 30 40 60; do md2D -param p.txt -N $N -verbosity 0 -profile_name conv/N$N; done
grep -H one_minus_sum_eff conv/*.txt
```

- `one_minus_sum_eff` tracks the NS convergence for lossless structures, but **not** the N convergence. Compare the efficiencies you need between successive N.
- Typical outcome: dielectric gratings converge with slices of $\lambda/100$ – $\lambda/1000$ and N just above the number of propagating orders. Metals in TM need slices of $\lambda/1000$ or finer and N of 30–50.

4 Lamellar gratings and stacks

Binary structures (vertical walls, flat tops) are best described as a stack (`MULTICOUCHES`) and computed with `calcul_method = Z_INVAR` . Each z-invariant layer is then propagated exactly, like RCWA. Use enough slices that each stays thin, $NS \geq N \cdot h/L$: a single thick slice overflows at large N.

```
# line of material n1 (width 40 % of the period) on the substrate
utils/profilGen CARRE02_B -L1 0.4 -h1 0.2 -h2 0 -N_profil 1024 > line_raw.txt
{ echo "n1 = 1.46 + i0.0"; cat line_raw.txt; } > line.txt
```

- For more materials, add columns (one per interface, top to bottom) and indices `n2` , `n3` ... (manual § 5). `profilGen CARRE03` , `RECTANGLE04` and `TRAPEZ02` write such files.
- Sloped walls (trapezoids) are no longer z-invariant: use `RK4` with enough slices, or `Z_INVAR` as an explicit staircase approximation in TE only.
- `imposed_S_steps = AUTO` (md2D) places the slice boundaries on the horizontal interfaces found in the file, so that no slice straddles one.

5 Rough surfaces and non-periodic objects

A non-periodic surface is computed as one period of a large artificial period L . The diffracted orders then sample the scattering diagram with a step $\Delta(\sin \theta) = \lambda/(vL)$.

```
utils/profilGen ALEAT01 -N_profil 2048 -Ag 1 -Lg 20 -Ae 0 > rough.txt # Gaussian-correlated random profile
md2D -param rough_param.txt -L 50.3 -N AUTO -h 0.2 -profile_name rough_TE
```

The scattered intensity per unit angle (per radian) of each order is

$$dI/d\theta(\theta_n) = (L/\lambda) v \cos \theta_n e_n,$$

with v the index of the medium where it is observed.

- **N must cover every propagating order:** $N \geq (\max(v_1, v_2) + v_1 |\sin \theta_i|) \cdot L/\lambda$, plus a margin. `N = AUTO` does this. Too small an N silently drops orders while the energy balance still looks perfect. The cost grows as N^3 , so an L of 50λ means $N \approx 110$ and about a minute per run in md2D.
- **Avoid Rayleigh anomalies.** If an order is exactly grazing ($v \sin \theta_n = \pm v$ exactly, e.g. $L = 50\lambda$ at $\theta = 30^\circ$), the results are `nan` . Shift L or θ slightly ($L = 50.3\lambda$).
- The profile length L must be many correlation lengths long. The heights are rescaled to span `h` , so set `h` (peak-to-valley) from the wanted rms and the profile statistics. Average $dI/d\theta$ over several random profiles for a smooth diagram.
- The same approach handles an isolated defect or line: put one object in a large period of flat surface.

6 Near-field maps

`calcul_type = NEAR_FIELD` (md2D) writes the field inside the computation box to the terminal, one row per slice (NS rows of N_x values). A complete example, a copper edge in silicon at 10.6 μm , is in [Applications/ExempleUtilisationNearField/](#).

```
md2D -param param_snomIR_edges.txt -calcul_type NEAR_FIELD -pola TM -verbosity 0 > field.txt
for c in ReEx ImEx ReEz ImEz ReHpy ImHpy; do utils/lire_tab2 $c < field.txt > $c.txt; done
```

- Put `h_min` / `h_max` in the structure file to extend the box above and below the structure, so the map includes some air and substrate.
- The vertical resolution is h/NS and the horizontal one L/N_x . Use `Z_INVAR` for binary structures: fields near sharp edges are singular and need a large N to resolve.

7 3D structures and conical incidence

Biperiodic surface

Write an `H_XY` file from any function $z(x,y)$; md3D computes the normals itself. For example, the pyramid of the validation cases:

```
python3 thesis_validation_cases/tools/mkprofile.py pyramid pyramid_512x512.txt --n 512
# or, for your own shape:
python3 - <<'EOF'
import math
n = 256
with open("mysurf.txt", "w") as f:
    f.write("profile_type = H_XY\nNpx = %d\nNpy = %d\nprofil =\n" % (n, n))
    for j in range(n):
        # rows: y
        f.write(" ".join("%.8e" % (math.sin(2*math.pi*i/n) + math.sin(2*math.pi*j/n))
                        for i in range(n)) + "\n")
        # columns: x
EOF
```

Conical incidence on a 1D grating

Use md3D with `Ny = 0`, a one-row profile (`Npy = 1`) and any `Ly`.

[thesis_validation_cases/case06_conical_incidence_vs_gsolver/](#) is a complete example (lamellar grating, $\theta = 30^\circ$, $\varphi = 45^\circ$, $\psi = 45^\circ$).

Holes, pillars and other z-invariant patterns

Use an `N_XY_ZINVAR` index map with `calcul_method = Z_INVAR`. `NS = 1` is fine for thin patterned layers like this one ($h = 0.05 L$); follow `NS  $\geq$  N·h/L` for thicker ones:

```
python3 thesis_validation_cases/tools/mkprofile.py circle holes.txt --n 1024 --R 0.25 --L 1.0 \
--n1 "1.0 + i0.0" --n2 "1.75 + i1.5"
```

Use 512 or more points per side; the 128-point map gives a $3 \cdot 10^{-4}$ offset. The normal field is radial and centred on the cell, which suits centred round shapes only (manual § 8).

Planning the cost

$N_x = N_y$	HARMONICS	TIME PER RUN (PYRAMID, $NS = 20$, OPENBLAS, AUTOMATIC THREADS)
4	81	1 s
6	169	4 s
8	289	26 s
10	441	1.6 min
15	961	≈ 20 min (extrapolated)

Time grows linearly with NS. With the reference BLAS instead of OpenBLAS these times are 3–8 times longer. Choose unequal `Nx` , `Ny` when the periods differ.

8 Material indices

- Indices go directly into the parameter or structure file as `n + ik` with $k \geq 0$ for absorption. Tabulated data for most materials are at refractiveindex.info.
- For a wavelength scan, interpolate the table in your script and pass the index on the command line at each step.
- `utils/refractive_index` reads material files in a spectroscopic-ellipsometry format (see `md2D/Optimization_var_lambda/*_index.txt`). Its lookup mode takes the wavelength in nm; the Cauchy mode is currently unreachable (the method argument is ignored).

9 Troubleshooting

SYMPTOM	CAUSE AND FIX
<code>ERROR</code> , can't read <code>"fft_filter"</code> (or another key)	A required key is missing from the parameter file (manual § 4). Old parameter files lack <code>fft_filter</code> .
can't read <code>"l_smooth"</code>	<code>smoothing = 1</code> requires <code>l_smooth</code> (thickness of the transition layer). Older builds also showed this when <code>smoothing</code> was absent; the current code defaults it to 0.
<code>nan</code> efficiencies	An order is exactly grazing (Rayleigh anomaly). Change L or θ slightly. With a metal substrate, <code>nan</code> in <code>theta_t</code> is normal.
Efficiencies far above 1 or wildly varying (metal, TM)	Too few slices: increase <code>NS</code> until $h/NS \leq \lambda/1000$.
Good energy balance but results change with N	Not converged in N; energy conservation cannot detect it. Increase N.
Weak orders off by a few %	Structure file too coarse for the number of harmonics. Use more points (≥ 2048 in 2D for $N \approx 100$).
Orders appear mirrored ($n \leftrightarrow -n$) compared with another code	Different x or angle orientation. Mirror the profile or change the sign of θ .
<code>h determined ... is ...</code> and <code>h indicated ...</code>	Information only: the profile is rescaled to <code>h</code> (x <code>coef_h</code>). Use <code>h = AUTO</code> to keep the file's height.
A result file disappeared or was replaced	Two runs used the same <code>profile_name</code> .
Debug lines (<code>MxV</code> , <code>pointer par->...</code>) at verbosity 0	Leftover prints in md2D; harmless.
md3D very slow	Expected $\propto$ harmonics ³ . Check that OpenBLAS is in use (<code>ldd md3D/md3D grep blas</code>), or lower <code>Nx</code> , <code>Ny</code> .

10 Older material in the repository

- `md2D/Optimization_var_lambda/` : fitting of a line's width and height to spectroscopic-ellipsometry data with Levenberg–Marquardt (scatterometry, thesis Part 2). It relies on a `calcul_type = ELLIPSO` that the current md2D no longer provides, so it needs porting before use.
- `Applications/` : the near-field example and two Octave scripts for post-processing (`inverse_reflexion_TE.m` , `inverse_reflexion_TM.m`).
- `PROVENANCE.md` : history of the code and of the removed older variants.